Current Affairs 02-11-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

World Bank’s India Poverty and Equity Brief

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For Prelims: World Bank , Poverty , Multidimensional Poverty Index , Gini index , NITI Aayog , PM Kaushal Vikas Yojana , Female Labor Force Participation Rate

For Mains: Social Justice and Vulnerable Sections, Poverty, Regional Disparities and Inclusive Development.

Source: TH

Why in News?

The **World Bank** released the **India Poverty and Equity Brief (October 2026)** , highlighting that India has achieved one of the fastest **poverty** reduction rates globally.

- However, while absolute monetary poverty has declined, critical macroeconomic vulnerabilities and structural inequalities threaten to undermine this progress.

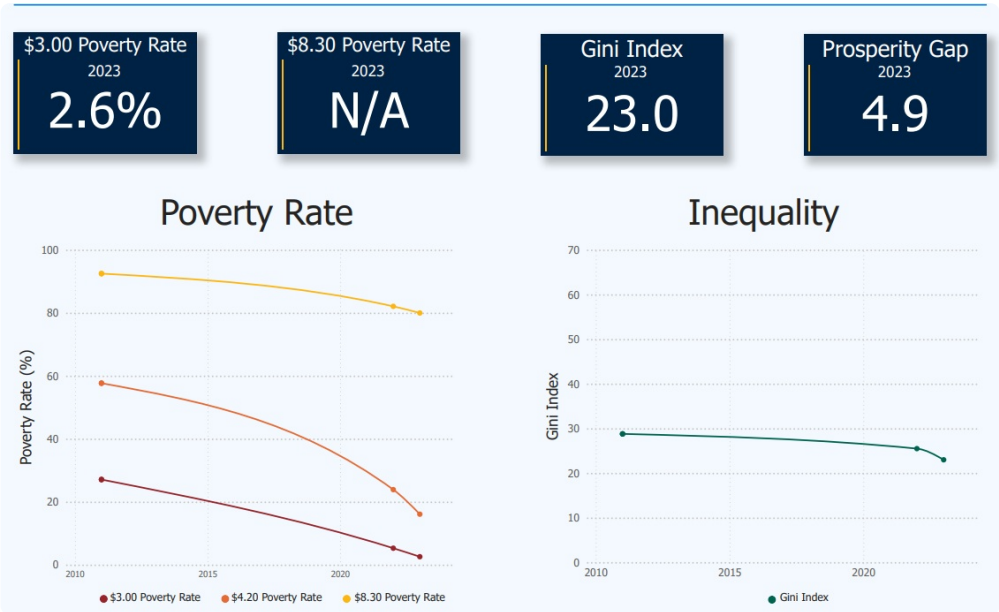
Summary

- India has made significant progress, with 496 million people lifted out of poverty between 2011 and 2023, driven by economic growth, rising employment and social welfare schemes.
- Inequality, unemployment, agrarian distress and social exclusion continue to hinder poverty eradication, requiring inclusive growth, better human capital and equitable wealth distribution.

What are the Key Findings of the India Poverty and Equity Brief?

- **Absolute Reduction in Poverty:** Between 2011 and 2023, the share of the population below the Lower Middle-Income poverty line (USD 4.20/day) fell drastically from **57.7% to 16.1%** , successfully lifting an estimated **496 million people** out of poverty.
    - Poverty decline is expected to slow down, with projections indicating a drop from **14.2% in 2026 to 12.1% by 2028** (at the USD 4.20 line).

- **Decline in Extreme Poverty:** Extreme poverty (measured at USD 3.00/day) plummeted from **27.1% to 2.6%** , leaving roughly 75.2 million people in extreme poverty by 2023.
- **Non-Monetary/Multidimensional Improvements:** According to the **Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative (OPHI),** India's **Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI)** poverty rate declined from 53.8% (2005–06) to 16.4% (2019–21).
  - The World Bank's MPI estimated it at 15.5% in 2022–23.
- **Regional Concentration:** A contiguous belt of states stretching from **Uttar Pradesh to West Bengal accounts for about 57%** of India's remaining poor.
  - National poverty eradication heavily depends on generating productive employment in this specific region.
- **Rural-Urban Divide:** Most of the poor remain in rural areas, where poverty sits at **19.3% compared to 8.6% in urban areas** , largely due to a lack of non-farm job opportunities and low productivity.
- **Demographic Vulnerabilities:** Poverty is highest among **children aged 0–14 (21.8%)** , followed by females (16.6%).
  - Poverty affects 21.3% of those with no education, but only 7.4% of those with tertiary education.
- **Severe Wage Inequality:** The report highlights a stark wage disparity, with the median earnings of the **top 10% of workers being 13 times** that of the bottom 10%. The **Gini index** stands at 23.0 (2023).
- **Drivers of Alleviation:** Progress was primarily driven by strong domestic consumption growth, rising employment (particularly among rural women), and expanded government social transfers like food subsidies.

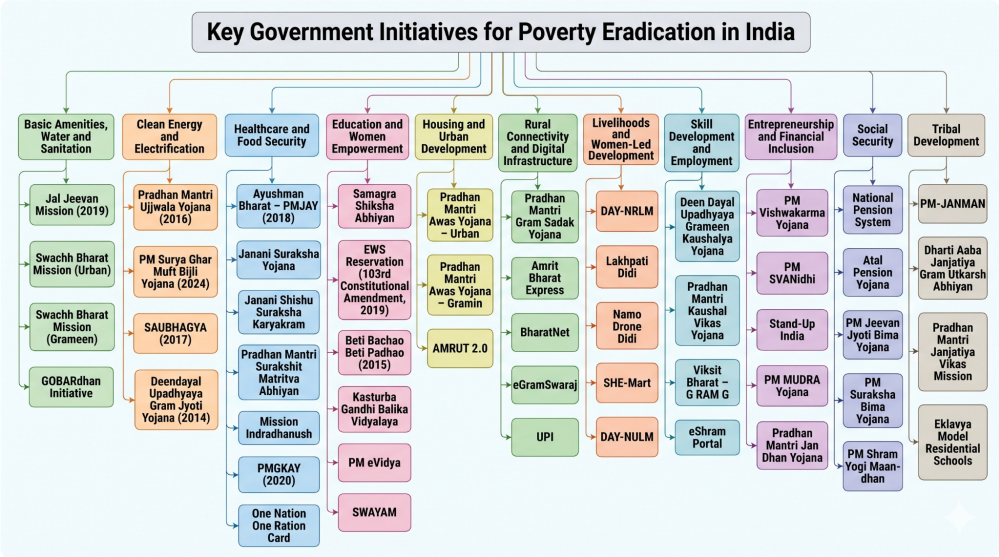


What is Poverty?

- **Poverty:** The World Bank defines **poverty as a pronounced deprivation in well-being,** where individuals lack sufficient income or consumption to meet a minimum standard of living.
  - It extends beyond income deprivation to include inadequate access to food, healthcare, education, housing and other basic necessities, as well as a lack of essential capabilities, dignity, empowerment and political freedom required to participate fully in society.
- **Measurement Categories** : Poverty is measured objectively (**monetary vs. non-monetary/basic needs/anthropometric**) or subjectively (direct surveys).
- **Monetary Poverty Calculation** : Involves three steps: estimating a **poverty line (absolute or**

relative) , selecting a **welfare aggregate (income or expenditure)** , and calculating the population share below this threshold.

- **Absolute Poverty** : Defined as lacking the monetary resources to afford a socially accepted **minimum consumption basket** .
- **Relative Poverty:** It refers to a condition in which individuals have significantly lower income or resources than the average or median income of the society.
  - It highlights economic inequality and relative deprivation, even when basic needs are met.
- **Poverty Estimation in India:** **NITI Aayog** oversees poverty estimation using household consumption expenditure data collected by the **National Sample Survey Office (NSSO)** under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).
  - The Ministry of Rural Development conducts the BPL Census to identify poor households for specific welfare schemes.
  - **Post-Independence:** The **Planning Commission (1962)** initiated official poverty estimation. The **Alagh Committee (1979) and Lakdawala Committee (1993)** refined the methodology using consumption expenditure and calorie norms.
  - **Tendulkar Committee (2009):** Shifted away from calorie-based norms, adopted a uniform **all-India Poverty Line Basket (PLB) and MRP data** .
    - It estimated the 2011–12 poverty line at Rs 816 (rural) and Rs 1,000 (urban) per capita per month.
  - **Rangarajan Committee (2014):** Recommended separate rural and urban PLBs, estimating poverty lines at **Rs 972 (rural) and Rs 1,407 (urban) per capita per month.** Its recommendations were not officially adopted by the government.



What are the Major Challenges Hindering Poverty Reduction in India?

- **Increasing Inequality:** The ***World Inequality Lab (2024)*** highlights that India's top **1% controls over 40% of national wealth** , indicating a systemic failure to fulfil **Article 39(c)** of the Constitution, which mandates the State to prevent the concentration of wealth.
- **Informalization and the 'Gig' Trap:** Neoliberal labor deregulation strips over 80% of the **workforce of social security and job permanence.**
  - This precariousness ensures that a single medical or economic shock instantly plunges vulnerable families back into destitution.

- **Jobless Growth:** Because India's GDP growth is highly capital-intensive, it fails to absorb **surplus agricultural labor.**
  - With **youth comprising 83% of the unemployed (ILO, 2024),** this structural bottleneck locks the **poor out of high-productivity manufacturing** , ensuring real wages remain permanently suppressed.
- **The Agrarian Debt Cycle:** Agriculture absorbs **45% of the workforce but yields only 18% of GDP.**
  - Fragmented landholdings, unpredictable monsoons, and market volatility trap farmers in **inescapable cycles of debt and disguised unemployment** , keeping rural incomes fundamentally stagnant.
- **Sociological Poverty Traps:** Poverty is continuously reproduced along caste lines through systemic marginalization, historical land alienation, and geographic displacement of **Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs)** (as noted by the **Xaxa Committee**), structurally barring them from accumulating generational wealth.
- **The Feminization of Poverty:** Relegating **women strictly to unpaid care work** or low-paying informal agricultural labor drastically suppresses total household earning potential.
  - This systemic exclusion denies women financial autonomy and ensures poverty is passed down to the next generation.
- **Biological Traps:** Despite caloric sufficiency, rampant micronutrient **deficiencies** evidenced by over **50% anemia in women and high child stunting rates (NFHS-5)** permanently impair the **cognitive and physical development of the next generation** , severely limiting their future earning capacity.
  - Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE) on healthcare accounts for roughly 47.1% to 48.2% of India's total health expenditure, continuing to drive an estimated 55 million people into poverty each year.
- **Climate-Induced Economic Resets:** The poor live in highly exposed geographies. Frequent **climate disasters (floods, heatwaves)** act as a relentless "reset button," repeatedly wiping out the **fragile physical assets,** livestock, and rudimentary housing of marginal farmers and urban slum dwellers.
- **Human Capital Deficit:** Chronically low **public expenditure on health** (1.3% of GDP) and education (2.9%) ensures the massive working-age population remains unskilled.
  - This deficit traps the youth in obsolete, low-end jobs, turning a potential demographic dividend into a cycle of poverty in an **AI-driven economy.**
- **Inflation as a Regressive Tax:** Persistent and volatile **food inflation** constantly erodes the already fragile purchasing power of low-income households.
  - It continuously nullifies any nominal wage gains, acting as an invisible tax that keeps vulnerable populations hovering just below or at the poverty line.
- **The Eldercare Financial Drain:** By 2050, **over 20% of India's population will be elderly.**
  - Without universal pension coverage and with the breakdown of joint families, the financial burden of eldercare **will fall squarely on impoverished youth, draining their meagre resources and deepening the household poverty trap.**

What Measures Can Strengthen Poverty Reduction in India?

To systematically address and strengthen poverty reduction in India, policymakers must adopt the **EMPOWER framework:** Employment, Marginalized Empowerment, Progressive Taxation, Overhauling Agriculture, Welfare, Education & Health, and Resilience.

- **Employment-Linked Incentives & Skilling:** Move beyond basic rural subsistence schemes like **VB-G**

RAM G , 2025 by integrating them with mandatory skilling initiatives (**PM Kaushal Vikas Yojana**) to create productive, climate-resilient assets.

- Implement **Employment-Linked Incentives (ELI)** schemes to subsidize formal hiring in labor-intensive sectors (textiles, toys, food processing) and mandate corporate apprenticeships to tackle youth 'jobless growth'.

- **Marginalized & Women Empowerment:** Go beyond micro-credit by aggressively onboarding Self-Help Groups (SHGs) onto the **Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC)** , eliminating middlemen and expanding market access to achieve the government's target of creating **3 crore 'Lakhpati Didis'** .
  - Rapidly deploy the planned **17,000 creches under the National Creche Scheme.** Unburdening women from unpaid care work is a strict prerequisite to pushing **India's Female Labor Force Participation Rate (FLFPR) past its current structural ceiling.**
  - Strictly enforce the 4% employment reservation under the **RPwD Act, 2016,** incentivise inclusive hiring, and strengthen the **Accessible India Campaign** to ensure the economic participation of PwDs.
- **Progressive Taxation:** Introduce progressive wealth and inheritance taxes on the ultra-rich to curb extreme wealth concentration, fulfilling the constitutional mandate of **Article 39(c).**
  - Use augmented direct tax revenues to statutorily increase public health spending to **2.5% of GDP** .
- **Overhauling Agriculture:** Implement universal **Kisan e-IDs** linked to land records and Aadhaar. This **Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI)** will enable instant, **collateral-free credit via the Kisan Credit Card (KCC),** breaking the reliance on exploitative informal moneylenders.
  - Shift procurement incentives away from water-guzzling crops (paddy/wheat) toward **Shree Anna (millets)** and pulses. This stabilizes incomes for dryland/marginal farmers who are most vulnerable to climate shocks.
- **Welfare Universalization:** Strengthen implementation of the **Code on Social Security, 2020** by levying a **1–2% cess on aggregator platform revenues** (e.g., Zomato, Uber) to fund a dedicated social security net (health, pension) for the 15+ million unorganized gig workers, mirroring the **Rajasthan Gig Workers Act, 2023** .
  - Under the **National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE),** shift focus from **hospital-based care to funding localized, community-led day-care centers** and at-home palliative care for the elderly, reducing the indirect wage-loss burden on working-age family members.
- **Education & Eradicating 'Hidden Hunger':** Execute the **NEP 2020** target to expose 100% of learners to vocational education by 2030, bridging the massive skills gap that drives youth unemployment.
  - Shift **Targeted Public Distribution System (TPDS)** towards a **nutrition-centric model** by including pulses, edible oils and **bio-fortified millets (Shree Anna)** to combat anaemia and stunting through dietary diversification.
- **Resilience:** Adopt parametric weather insurance for instant, weather-triggered payouts and establish a dedicated fund to reskill coal-dependent informal workers in Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and West Bengal during the transition towards **India's 2070 Net-Zero target.**

Conclusion

While lifting half a billion Indians out of extreme poverty is a historic achievement, true poverty eradication requires moving beyond basic subsistence towards equitable wealth distribution and human capital development. From **Antyodaya to Sarvodaya,** India must advance **SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 8 (Decent Work) and SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities)** while upholding the

Supreme Court's Olga Tellis judgment (1985), which recognises the Right to Livelihood.

Drishti Mains Question:

From Antyodaya to Sarvodaya, poverty eradication requires moving beyond welfare delivery towards equitable opportunities and human development. Examine.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What are the key findings of the World Bank's India Poverty and Equity Brief (October 2026)?
The poverty rate at the $4.20 per day poverty line declined from 57.7% in 2011 to 16.1% in 2023, lifting an estimated 496 million people out of poverty.

2. What is the difference between absolute and relative poverty?
Absolute poverty: Inability to meet minimum basic consumption needs.

Relative poverty: Deprivation compared to the average or median living standards of society.

3. Which committees shaped poverty estimation in India?
The major committees include the Alagh (1979), Lakdawala (1993), Tendulkar (2009) and Rangarajan (2014) Committees, which refined poverty measurement methodologies.

4. What is the significance of Article 39(c) in poverty reduction?
Article 39(c) directs the State to prevent the concentration of wealth and means of production to the common detriment, promoting distributive justice.

5. How does the RPwD Act, 2016 promote economic inclusion?
It provides 4% reservation in government employment for persons with benchmark disabilities and promotes accessibility and equal participation.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/vlV06LGfIOc**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q . Consider the following statements about Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI): (2026)

1. MPI is calculated using Alkire-Foster methodology.
2. MPI calculated by NITI Aayog has a total of twelve indicators.
3. Maternal Health and Bank Account are common indicators in the MPI of NITI Aayog and MPI of United Nations Development Programme (UNDP).

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only

(b) 1, 2 and 3

(c) 1 and 3 only

(d) 2 only

Ans: (a)

Q. The Multi-dimensional Poverty Index developed by Oxford Poverty and Human Development Initiative with UNDP support covers which of the following? (2012)

1. Deprivation of education, health, assets and services at household level
2. Purchasing power parity at national level
3. Extent of budget deficit and GDP growth rate at national level

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

(a) 1 only

(b) 2 and 3 only

(c) 1 and 3 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. Inequality in the ownership pattern of resources is one of the major causes of poverty. Discuss in the context of ‘paradox of poverty’. **(2025)**

Q. Poverty and malnutrition create a vicious cycle, adversely affecting human capital formation. What steps can be taken to break the cycle? **(2024)**

Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana

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Source: TH

Why in News?

Recently, the **Union Cabinet** approved the **Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana** , aimed at strengthening grassroots governance and **Panchayati Raj Institutions** across India.

What are the Key Facts About the Scheme?

- About: The Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana (PM VGSY) is a **Centrally Sponsored Scheme** aimed at strengthening Panchayats as empowered, self-reliant, accountable and high-performing institutions of local self-government through integrated planning, capacity building and digital governance.
- **Implementation Period:** The scheme will be implemented from **FY 2026–27 to 2030–31** , with a total financial outlay of **₹7,395.55 crore** , comprising a Central share of ₹4,869.48 crore and a State share of ₹2,526.07 crore.
- **Institutional Coverage:** Covers **over 2.55 lakh Panchayats and traditional local bodies** across all States and Union Territories, including eligible traditional rural local government institutions in areas where Panchayats under Part IX of the Constitution do not exist.
- **Beneficiaries:** Around **32 lakh elected representatives, Panchayat functionaries and other stakeholders** will benefit through capacity building, technical support and digital handholding.
- **Finance Commission Linkage:** The scheme coincides with the **16 th Finance Commission (2026–31)** period, which has recommended approximately **₹4.35 lakh crore in grants for Rural Local Bodies** , and aims to strengthen Panchayats' capacity to utilise these resources effectively.
- **Implementation Mechanism:** The scheme will operate through **existing government institutions** , with States and UTs submitting **Annual Action Plans** for appraisal and approval by a **Central Empowered Committee** . It also provides for need-based contractual personnel at State, District and Block levels, without creating permanent posts.

What are the Six Pillars of the Scheme?

- **Gram Panchayats as Hubs of Local Governance:** Positions Gram Panchayats at the **centre of local development planning** , enabling them to coordinate village priorities, government schemes and available resources while aligning national development goals with local needs.
- **Holistic Planning at Gram Panchayat Level:** Integrates Central and State departmental planning processes through a **common digital platform** to strengthen **Gram Panchayat Development Plans (GPDPs)** , identify development gaps and improve resource utilisation.
- **Digital Governance:** Builds on **eGramSwaraj and existing e-Panchayat systems** to consolidate information on government schemes, beneficiaries, community assets and available resources, improving planning, monitoring and knowledge-sharing among Panchayats.

- **Connecting National Priorities with Local Needs:** Promotes **Jan Bhagidari (people's participation)** through Gram Sabhas, Panchayat forums and digital outreach. The **AI-enabled PANCHAM (Panchayat Assistance and Messaging Chatbot)** facilitates multilingual, two-way communication in **17 Indian languages** .
- **Capacity Building:** Strengthens the skills of elected representatives and Panchayat functionaries through **Integrated Government Online Training and the National Academy for Capacity Building of Civil Services** , covering digital governance, development planning, resource management and specialised technical tasks.
- **Transparent and Efficient Resource Utilisation:** Promotes effective utilisation of **Finance Commission grants** , mobilisation of **Own Source Revenue (OSR)** and financial accountability through online accounting, auditing and public disclosure.



What are the Key Targets of the Scheme?

- **Development Planning:** Preparation of **over 2.55 lakh Gram Panchayat Development Plans (GPDPs) annually** through eGramSwaraj, integrating local priorities, departmental interventions and available resources.
- **Citizen Awareness:** Reaching **at least 1 crore citizens per awareness-generation episode** through Gram Sabhas, digital platforms and outreach campaigns.
- **Capacity Building:** Providing training and digital support to around **32 lakh elected representatives, Panchayat functionaries and other stakeholders annually** to strengthen local governance and progress towards Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).
- **Financial Accountability:** Preparation of **at least 2.55 lakh online audit plans annually** , with timely audits through **AuditOnline** to improve transparency and accountability in Panchayat finances.

How Will Digital Platforms Strengthen Panchayat Governance?

The scheme builds on existing digital systems rather than creating an entirely separate governance infrastructure.

Digital platform	Key function
eGramSwaraj	Supports Panchayat planning, budgeting, accounting, monitoring, asset management and online payments.
PANCHAM	WhatsApp-based tool launched in January 2026 for two-way communication, scheme updates, training content and Panchayat service information.
AuditOnline	Facilitates **online audits of Panchayati Raj accounts** and supports financial transparency.

Conclusion

The **Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana** seeks to strengthen **decentralised, participatory and accountable rural governance** through integrated planning, digital governance, capacity building and transparent financial management. Its success will depend on effective implementation, meaningful community participation and the ability of Panchayats to translate local priorities into development outcomes, contributing to **inclusive rural development and the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047.**

Drishti Mains Practice Questions

The effectiveness of decentralised governance depends not merely on the devolution of functions and funds but also on institutional capacity and accountability. Discuss in the context of the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana. (150 words)

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Gram Swaraj Yojana?
It is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme approved to strengthen Panchayats through integrated planning, capacity building, digital governance and financial accountability.

2. How many stakeholders are expected to benefit directly?
Around 32 lakh elected representatives, Panchayat functionaries and other stakeholders.

3. What are the major annual planning and audit targets?
More than 2.55 lakh Gram Panchayat Development Plans and at least 2.55 lakh online audit plans.

4. Which digital platforms are associated with the scheme?
eGramSwaraj, PANCHAM and AuditOnline, alongside the proposed integrated digital platform.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/0BP7pgWh0mo]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQ)

Prelims

Q1. Local self-government can be best explained as an exercise in (2017)

(A) Federalism

(B) Democratic decentralisation

(C) Administrative delegation

(D) Direct democracy

Ans: (b)

Q2. The fundamental object of the Panchayati Raj system is to ensure which among the following? (2015)

1. People’s participation in development
2. Political accountability
3. Democratic decentralisation
4. Financial mobilisation

Select the correct answer using the code given below

(a) 1, 2 and 3 only

(b) 2 and 4 only

(c) 1 and 3 only

(d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Ans: (c)

Mains

Q1. Assess the importance of the Panchayat system in India as a part of local government. Apart from government grants, what sources can the Panchayats look out for financing developmental projects? **(2018)**

Q2. To what extent, in your opinion, has the decentralisation of power in India changed the governance landscape at the grassroots? **(2022)**

Catch the Rain Campaign

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The **Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari: Catch the Rain (JSJB: CTR) 2026 initiative** has strengthened **India's community-led water conservation efforts, integrating rainwater harvesting, groundwater recharge and restoration of water bodies** .

What are the Key Facts About the Catch the Rain Campaign?

- **About:** The **Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain (JSA: CTR) campaign was launched on 22nd March 2021,** coinciding with **World Water Day** , under the theme **“Catch the Rain, Where It Falls, When It Falls.”**
- **Background** : Builds upon the **Jal Shakti Abhiyan, 2019** , which covered 1,592 water-stressed blocks across 256 districts to promote water conservation and groundwater recharge.
- **Major Objectives:** Promotes rainwater harvesting, groundwater recharge, rejuvenation of traditional water bodies, watershed development and afforestation through community participation.
- **Key Interventions:**
  - Installation of **rainwater harvesting systems** , recharge pits and recharge shafts in residential, institutional and public spaces.
  - **Revival of traditional wells, baolis, ponds and abandoned borewells** to strengthen groundwater recharge.
  - **Desilting of ponds and reservoirs** to improve water storage capacity and monsoon water retention.
  - **Afforestation and catchment-area protection** to enhance ecological resilience and water conservation.
- **Community Participation:** Promotes water conservation as a **Jan Andolan (people's movement)** involving citizens, local governments, educational institutions and civil society organisations.
- **Jal Shakti Kendras (JSKs):** Function as district-level knowledge and facilitation centres, providing technical guidance and supporting local water conservation planning.

What are the Key Initiatives under Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari?

Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari 1.0 (2024)

- **About:** Implemented from **April 2024 to May 2025,** JSJB 1.0 promoted community-driven water conservation through locally appropriate groundwater recharge and water storage structures.
- **Three Cs Approach:** Based on **Community, Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Cost** , encouraging public participation, private-sector contributions and low-cost interventions.
- **Convergence:** Integrated resources from existing government schemes through a **Whole-of-Government and Whole-of-Society** approach.
- **Achievements:** More than 10 lakh groundwater recharge structures were constructed, with over 27 lakh artificial recharge structures reported during the initiative.

Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari 2.0 (2025)

- **About:** Launched on **1st June 2025, JSJB 2.0** expanded community-led water conservation efforts, particularly in over-exploited and critical groundwater districts.
- **Focus Areas:** Emphasised low-cost, hyper-local groundwater recharge interventions, revival of water sources and community ownership.
- **Recognition:** Outstanding contributions under JSJB 1.0 were recognised during the 6th National Water Awards in November 2025.

Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari: Catch the Rain (2026)

- **About:** Launched on 1st June 2026, it integrates JSJB with the Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain campaign to strengthen water conservation and climate resilience.
- **Inter-Scheme Convergence:** Mobilises resources from programmes such as **VB-G RAM G** , **PM Krishi Sinchayee Yojana (PMKSY)** , **CAMPA** , **Finance Commission** Grants and State Government schemes.
- **Local Participation:** Involves Panchayati Raj Institutions, Urban Local Bodies, women's groups, youth, educational institutions and civil society organisations in planning and implementation.
- **Digital Monitoring:** Uses the JSJB: CTR Portal and mobile application to support transparency, progress monitoring and public feedback.

Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain (JSA: CTR)

- **Building on JSA 2019:** The campaign builds on **Jal Shakti Abhiyan 2019** , which covered **1,592 water-stressed blocks across 256 districts** and promoted water conservation and rainwater harvesting.
- **Key Focus Areas:** It promotes **rainwater harvesting, groundwater recharge, watershed development, rejuvenation of water bodies, afforestation and community participation** through a **Jan Andolan** approach.
- **Annual Campaign:** The campaign has been **implemented annually** , with its themes and focus areas evolving over time.

Major Achievements

- **Over 1.55 crore artificial recharge and storage structures** have been constructed under the broader JSJB initiative.
- An impact evaluation of 23 lakh structures under JSJB 1.0, using rainfall data from June to December 2025, estimated 2.43 billion cubic metres of groundwater recharge.

Year	Theme / Focus	Key Areas of Activity
2021	**Catch the Rain, Where It Falls, When It Falls**	Rainwater harvesting and water conservation; geo-tagging of water bodies; scientific water conservation planning; Jal Shakti Kendras and awareness activities
2022	**Expanding Water Conservation Activities**	Restoration of traditional water bodies; groundwater recharge and watershed development; wetland and river rejuvenation; spring-shed development and catchment protection
2023	**Source Sustainability for Drinking Water**	Focus on 150 water-stressed districts; strengthening drinking water sources; groundwater recharge and source sustainability; field monitoring and community participation
2024	**Nari Shakti se Jal Shakti**	Women-led water conservation initiatives; desilting and cleaning of water bodies; revival of abandoned borewells for recharge; afforestation and rejuvenation of local water resources
2025	**Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari: Jan Jagrukta ki Ore**	Community participation in 148 priority districts; groundwater recharge, water-body restoration, scheme convergence through the **3Cs (Community, CSR, Cost) and awareness campaigns.**

Conclusion

The Catch the Rain Campaign and Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari represent a **shift towards decentralised, community-driven and scientifically informed** water conservation. Integrating local participation, traditional water-management practices, digital monitoring and scheme convergence can strengthen groundwater security, **climate resilience and sustainable rural development.**

Drishti Mains Question

Community participation and decentralised planning are essential for addressing India's growing water security challenges. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is the Catch the Rain Campaign?
It is a nationwide water conservation campaign promoting rainwater harvesting, groundwater recharge, restoration of traditional water bodies and community participation.

Q2. When was Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain launched?
It was launched on 22 March 2021, coinciding with World Water Day.

Q3. What are the three Cs of Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari?
The three Cs are Community, Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Cost, promoting participatory and cost-effective water conservation.

Q4. What are the major achievements of the JSJB initiative?
According to PIB's October 2026 backgrounder, over 1.55 crore artificial recharge and storage structures have been constructed. An impact evaluation covering 23 lakh structures estimated 2.43 billion cubic metres of groundwater recharge.

Q5. What is Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari: Catch the Rain (2026)?
Launched on 1 June 2026, it integrates JSJB with the Catch the Rain campaign to strengthen community-led water conservation, inter-scheme convergence and technology-enabled monitoring.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/ViZAaS53cm8]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions

Prelims

Q. Which of the following statements can help in water conservation in agriculture? (2017)

1. Reduced or zero tillage of the land
2. Applying gypsum before irrigating the field
3. Allowing crop residue to remain in the field

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

a) 1 and 2 only

b) 3 only

c) 1 and 3 only

d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (c)

Mains

Q. Examine the factors responsible for depleting groundwater in India. What are the steps taken by the government to mitigate such depletion of groundwater? **(2025)**

2 Years of Ayushman Vay Vandana Initiative

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Source: TH

Why in News?

Recently, the **Ayushman Vay Vandana** initiative completed two years, recording 23.46 lakh authorised hospital admissions worth ₹5,668.80 crore as of October 2026.

What are the Key Facts About Ayushman Vay Vandana Initiative?

- **About:** The Ayushman Vay Vandana initiative **, launched on 29 th October 2024,** extends the benefits of **Ayushman Bharat–Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB PM-JAY)** to all senior citizens aged 70 years and above, irrespective of their socio-economic status.
- **Implementing Agency:** Implemented by the **National Health Authority (NHA)** under **the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare,** aiming **to strengthen healthcare access and financial protection for the elderly.**
- **Coverage:** Provides health coverage of **up to ₹5 lakh per family annually for secondary and tertiary care hospitalisation,** benefiting approximately 6 crore senior citizens across 4.5 crore families.
- **Additional Benefits:** Senior citizens aged **70 years and above** belonging to families already covered under AB PM-JAY receive an **additional ₹5 lakh annual top-up cover,** exclusively for themselves, separate from the existing family coverage.
- **Ayushman Vay Vandana Card:** Eligible senior citizens receive a distinct **Ayushman Vay Vandana Card, with Aadhaar-based e-KYC mandatory** for enrolment. Registration is available through the **Ayushman App and the AB PM-JAY beneficiary portal.**
- **Existing Health Insurance:** Senior citizens covered under government schemes such as **CGHS, ECHS and CAPF** can choose between their existing scheme and **AB PM-JAY.** Those with private health insurance or **Employees' State Insurance (ESI) are also eligible.**
- **Significance:** Promotes **inclusive and cashless healthcare, reduces out-of-pocket hospitalisation expenses** and strengthens financial security and dignity among elderly citizens.

Major Achievements

- **Hospital Admissions:** Recorded **23.46 lakh authorised hospital admissions** , valued at **₹5,668.80 crore** .
- **Most Availed Treatments: Cataract surgery** accounted for 4.71 lakh treatments (20.1%), followed

by **chronic haemodialysis** with approximately 2.90 lakh treatments.

- **Cardiac Care: Percutaneous Transluminal Coronary Angioplasty (PTCA)** accounted for the highest authorised treatment expenditure of approximately **₹649 crore** .
- **Other Major Treatments:** Included total knee replacement, management of **Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease (COPD)** exacerbations, acute febrile illness, acute kidney injury and renal failure.

Ayushman Bharat–Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB PM-JAY)

- Launched in 2018 under the **Ayushman Bharat initiative** to improve access to affordable healthcare and protect economically vulnerable families from high hospitalisation expenses.
- It is a **government-funded health assurance scheme** providing cashless health coverage of up to ₹5 lakh per eligible family per year for secondary and tertiary care hospitalisation.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. When was Ayushman Vay Vandana launched?
It was launched on October 29, 2024.

2. Who is eligible for the initiative?
All senior citizens aged 70 years and above, irrespective of socio-economic status.

3. What is the annual health coverage provided?
Up to ₹5 lakh per family annually for secondary and tertiary care hospitalisation.

5. Which agency implements the initiative?
The National Health Authority (NHA) under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.

6. What additional benefit is available to existing AB PM-JAY families?
Eligible senior citizens receive an additional top-up cover of up to ₹5 lakh annually, exclusively for themselves.

7. How many hospital admissions were recorded in two years?
23.46 lakh authorised hospital admissions worth ₹5,668.80 crore, as of October 20, 2026.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/CFveMJclMi4]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. With reference to Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission, consider the following statements: (2022)

1. Private and public hospitals must adopt it.
2. As it aims to achieve universal health coverage, every citizen of India should be part of it ultimately.
3. It has seamless portability across the country.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only

(B) 3 only

(C) 1 and 3 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (b)

Q. With reference to the National Rural Health Mission, which of the following are the jobs of 'ASHA', a trained community health worker? (2012)

1. Accompanying women to the health facility for antenatal care checkup
2. Using pregnancy test kits for early detection of pregnancy
3. Providing information on nutrition and immunization.
4. Conducting the delivery of baby

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

(A) 1, 2 and 3 only

(B) 2 and 4 only

(C) 1 and 3 only

(D) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Ans: (a)

Mains

Q. The public health system has limitations in providing universal health coverage. Do you think that the private sector could help in bridging the gap? What other viable alternatives would you suggest? **(2015)**

SC to Review ‘Industry’ Definition Under IR Code, 2020

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Source: BS

The **Supreme Court of India** has agreed to hear a petition filed by the **All India Trade Union Congress (AITUC)** challenging the **constitutional validity of the definition of 'industry' under the Industrial Relations Code, 2020.** The core of the dispute lies in the Code's **exclusion of specific institutions,** fundamentally altering how industrial disputes and worker protections are governed.

- **Statutory Definition and Exclusions:** The Industrial Relations Code, 2020 (which amalgamates the **Trade Unions Act, 1926; the Industrial Employment (Standing Orders) Act, 1946; and the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947**) defines an 'industry' as any systematic activity carried out through cooperation between an employer and workers for the production, supply, or distribution of goods and services.
  - However, it explicitly **excludes** :
    - Institutions owned or managed by organizations substantially engaged in **charitable, social, or philanthropic activities** .
    - Government activities related to **sovereign functions** .
    - Domestic services.
    - Any other activities that the **Central Government may notify** at its discretion.
- **Constitutional Challenge:** The exclusions are challenged for potentially violating **Article 14 (Right to Equality) of the Constitution.**
  - Because the exclusion relies on **who runs the establishment rather than the work performed, workers doing identical jobs** (e.g., a nurse in a private commercial hospital versus a charitable hospital) face disparate access to **Industrial Tribunals** and dispute remedies.
- **Excessive Delegation:** The Code empowers the Central Government to notify additional activities excluded from the definition of 'industry' without expressly prescribing limiting criteria, raising concerns over arbitrary classification and excessive executive discretion.
- **Deviation from Established Precedent:** The 2020 Code's definition departs from the landmark **Supreme Court judgment in *Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board v. A. Rajappa (1978)*** , which established the "triple test (systematic activity, employer-employee cooperation, and production of goods/services)" and ruled that the **nature of the activity,** not the employer’s identity or profit motive, determines what constitutes an 'industry'.
- **Jai Bir Singh Case (August 2026):** The Supreme Court held that the Bangalore Water Supply (1978) triple test would continue to govern pending disputes under the **Industrial Disputes Act, 1947.**
  - However, the Bench clarified that the definition of 'industry' under Section 2(p) of the **Industrial Relations Code, 2020** , must be interpreted independently, making this current constitutional scrutiny essential.
- **Impact on Worker Protections:** Workers in excluded establishments do not lose all legal rights, but they are stripped of the specific **statutory protections regarding retrenchment, lay-offs, closure, and conciliation machinery** explicitly provided under the Industrial Relations Code.

Read more: Nationwide Implementation of India's Four Labour Codes

India Deepens Diplomatic Outreach to Central Asia

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Source: TH

India's External Affairs Minister visited **Baku, Azerbaijan** to review bilateral ties and also met **Uzbekistan's Foreign Minister** , reflecting India's renewed focus on strengthening engagement with the **Central Asian region.**

- **India-Azerbaijan:** Both sides agreed to expand cooperation in **trade, investment, energy, tourism, connectivity and people-to-people ties** .
  - India-Azerbaijan relations were weakened after Azerbaijan **opposed India's Operation Sindoor against Pakistan** . The visit marked efforts to improve relations.
  - Both countries support the **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)** , linking India with Iran, the Caspian region, Russia, Central Asia and Europe.
- **India-Uzbekistan:** India and Uzbekistan reviewed key bilateral issues and stressed the **timely implementation of agreements reached by their leaders** .
  - India-Uzbekistan ties were upgraded to a **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in August 2026** , with cooperation covering trade, mining, energy and uranium supply.

Central Asia Region



- **Geographical Location:** Central Asia lies in the interior of the Eurasian continent, with Russia to the north, China to the east, Iran and Afghanistan to the south, and the **Caspian Sea to the west** .
- **Member Countries:** The region consists of **five landlocked nations** , **Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan.**
  - All five gained independence following the dissolution of the Soviet Union in 1991.
- **Physical Features:** Major geographical features include the **Tian Shan and Pamir mountain ranges** , the **Karakum and Kyzylkum deserts,** and the **Amu Darya** and Syr Darya rivers, which historically drained into the **Aral Sea.**
- **Strategic Significance:** Central Asia was historically an important part of the Silk Road trade network and possesses substantial reserves of **oil, natural gas and uranium.**
- **Other Key Facts:**
  - **Kazakhstan** is the **world's largest landlocked country** by area.
  - **Uzbekistan** is a **doubly landlocked country** , meaning it is surrounded entirely by other landlocked countries.
  - **The Aral Sea, located between Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan,** has undergone severe shrinkage, largely due to the diversion of river water for irrigation.
  - **Lake Issyk-Kul** in **Kyrgyzstan** is the **world’s second-largest alpine lake** (after Lake Titicaca).
  - **Turkmenistan** is home to the **Darvaza Gas Crater,** a natural gas field that collapsed into a cavern in 1971 and has been burning continuously ever since.

Read More: Recalibrating India’s Central Asia Strategy

202nd Victory Celebration of Rani Chennamma

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Source: PIB

The **202nd anniversary of Kittur Rani Chennamma's victory against the British East India Company** was commemorated at **Prerana Sthal** in the Parliament premises, New Delhi, highlighting her role in the early resistance to British colonial rule.

- **About Rani Chennamma:** Rani Chennamma was born in **1778 in a Lingayat family** in Kakati village near **Belagavi, Karnataka.**
  - She was the **Queen of Kittur in present-day Karnataka** and an early leader of armed resistance against the **British East India Company** .



- **Kittur Rebellion:** In **1824** , Rani Chennamma opposed British efforts to take control of Kittur after they refused to recognise her adopted son **Shivalingappa** as heir.
  - In the first battle at Kittur in **1824** , British forces suffered heavy losses and political agent **St. John Thackeray was killed** .
  - Rani Chennamma was eventually captured and imprisoned at **Bailhongal Fort** , where she died on **21st February 1829** .
  - **Sangolli Rayanna** later continued resistance against British rule.
- **Legacy:**
  - Her victory is commemorated annually through the **Kittur Utsava** , held from **22nd-24th October** .
    - Also remembered across Karnataka through folk songs **(Janapada).**
  - A statue of Rani Chennamma was unveiled in the Parliament complex in **2007** .

Read More: Rani Chennamma

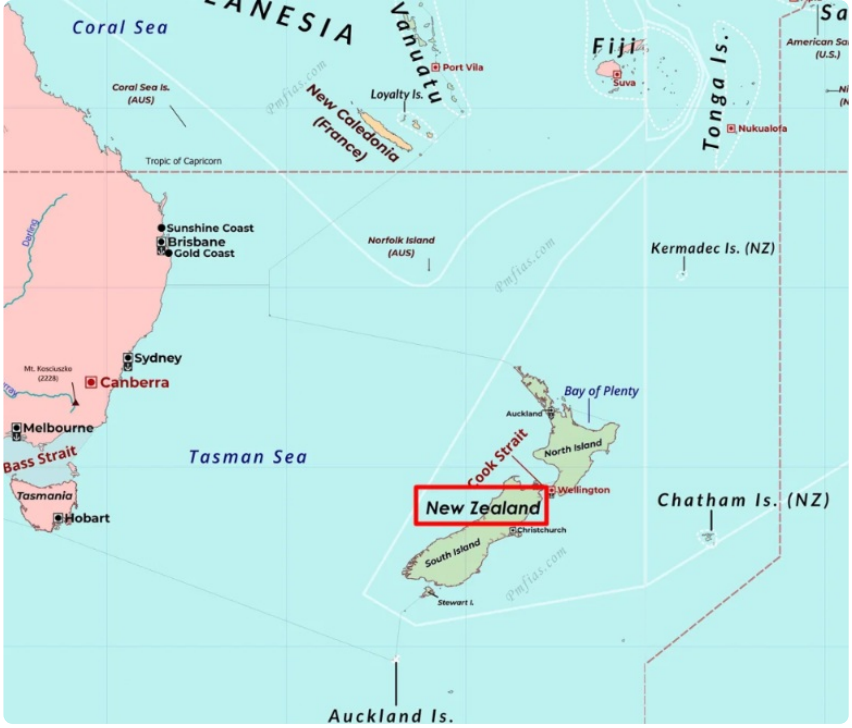
India-New Zealand MoC on Electronic Exchange of Origin Data

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Source: AIR

India and New Zealand signed a **Memorandum of Cooperation (MoC)** on electronic exchange of origin data for trade in goods. It was signed by the **Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) and the New Zealand Customs Service** to support the **India–New Zealand FTA.**

- **Rules of Origin** : These **are product-specific conditions that determine whether a good qualifies as an originating good under an FTA.** They can involve wholly obtained goods, tariff-classification change or value addition.
  - The **Customs (Administration of Rules of Origin under Trade Agreements) Rules, 2020** empower Indian Customs to verify origin claims made for preferential imports.
- The **India-New Zealand FTA** strengthens bilateral economic ties by providing duty-free access to **Indian exports, promoting investment, and expanding cooperation in agriculture, services and technology.**
  - India’s other recent FTA partners include the **EU, UAE, Australia, EFTA, UK, and Oman CEPA,** aimed at enhancing market access, boosting trade and investment, and strengthening economic partnerships.
- **About New Zealand** : **New Zealand** is an island country in the southwestern Pacific Ocean, forming part of **Polynesia** .
  - The **Tasman Sea** separates it from Australia, while the **Cook Strait** separates its North and South Islands.
  - Its capital is **Wellington** and it is **a member of the Five Eyes grouping.**
  - The country is known for its diverse landscapes, including active volcanoes, fjords, and the **Southern Alps** .
  - It has unique flora and fauna, including the flightless kiwi bird, which is also a national symbol. Formerly a **British colony, New Zealand gradually gained self-governance and became fully independent in 1947.**



Read More: India New Zealand FTA - Drishti IAS